

 MOTEL COACH

HOW TO RUN A MOTEL

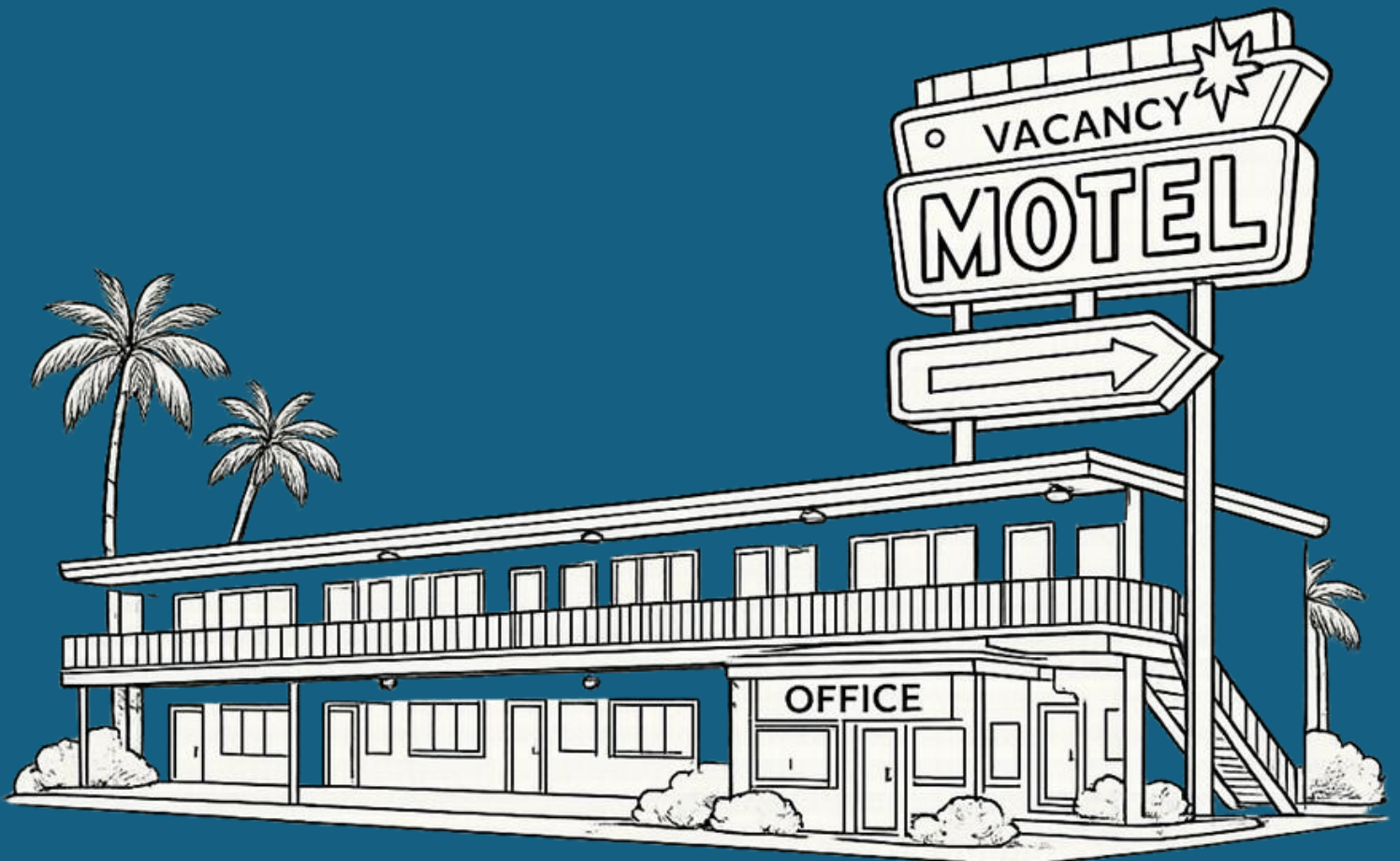


Table of Contents

Introduction

Chapter 2: Front Office

Chapter 3: Housekeeping

Chapter 4: Maintenance

Conclusion

Glossary

What to Do Next

Contact Us

Introduction

This guide was built for those managing or aspiring to run small motels. It's based on real industry experience—from housekeeping to general management—and is packed with practical tools, checklists, and templates. Whether you're a new owner, a family-run operator looking to tighten systems, this book helps you run smarter and more efficiently. Use it as a structured read-through or a reference manual by department. Expect long hours, diverse tasks, and hands-on responsibility—but also growth, confidence, and guest satisfaction when you apply the systems inside. This book is about action, not theory.

Chapter 2: Front Office

Reception is the guest's first point of contact and coordinates all motel departments. This section provides an actionable Front Desk Checklist and Best Practice Guide, with clear explanations and downloadable tools to help new managers run a smooth, professional front office.

Front Office Checklist

Start by downloading and printing the provided checklist. It covers the essential daily tasks at reception. As you gain experience, tweak it to suit your motel's needs—removing, shifting, or adding tasks as required. This checklist offers a strong foundation for understanding what must happen each day at the front office.

1. Review Overnight Activity

Check voicemails, messages, emails, and any shift handover notes.

2. Process / Check-out After-Hour Key Returns

Handle [express check-outs](#). If keys aren't returned, housekeeping can knock and enter rooms after cleaning departures.

✓ Best Practice: Knock three times, announce "Housekeeping," and enter slowly to minimise guest disruption.

3. Check-Out Guests

Ask for feedback about the guests stay and record it in their [guest profile](#).

✓ Tip: Ask specific questions like: "Do you have any feedback we can use to improve your next stay?"

Finalise accounts, remove any [pre-authorizations](#), and update [PMS](#) to [Vacant Dirty](#).

Inform housekeeper that is allocated that room – if they have already collected their list and started work.

✓ Best Practice: If a guest overstays, check for future bookings, consider offering a complimentary late checkout to enhance guest experience.

Invite happy guests to leave a review; skip this if issues occurred.

4. Sign Off on Cash [Float](#)

Check accuracy. Consistent records avoid future errors and build trust with your manager or motel owner.

✓ Tip: Owner's value financial accuracy—build trust by getting it right daily.

5. Open Motel Facilities

Unlock laundry, breakfast area, and reception. Do a property walk-through to check for hazards or misplaced items.

✓ Ensure facility hours are clearly communicated in-room and at check-in.

 [**Download: Daily Property Walk Checklist**](#)

6. Review Departures

Check the departure list and prepare for check-outs. Review any guests that have balances on their account.

7. Print and Review Arrivals List

Print the day's arrivals and highlight VIPs, early check-ins, and guest requests from your [PMS](#) or [OTA](#) platforms.

8. Prepare Housekeeping Room Lists

Assign rooms for [stayovers](#), departures, [VIPs](#), and deep cleans. Include specific notes like bed configurations (e.g., "[Split Beds](#): 2 Singles").

Communicate guest requests clearly with the Housekeeping Team. More communication will help the Housekeepers focus on what rooms need to be completed and will help you monitor the progress throughout the day.

Common requests include

- Early check-in,
- late arrival,
- asthma-friendly rooms,
- pet-friendly stays,
- separate beds – this might be a family or workers where they don't want to share a bed.
- rollaway bed
- Disabled room – when you allocate disabled rooms to non-disabled people due to availability put a note on it so that if you have changes later you can shuffle your rooms.
- floor preferences – this might be a simple preference, or it might be due to a mobility issue. When allocating

rooms try and keep a balance of upstairs and downstairs rooms available.

✓ Best Practice: Align guest room allocation with request notes and communicate with housekeeping promptly when guests request late check-outs or change plans to avoid housekeepers interrupting guests during stay.

9. Schedule Maintenance Tasks

Assign repairs before housekeeping where possible. Ensure all trades or external contractors have the appropriate licenses and sign in.

 [Download: Work Order Form](#)

 [Download: Maintenance Tracker](#)

 [Download: Contractor Sign-In Sheet](#)

10. Write Welcome Notes (Optional but Valuable)

A brief handwritten note and small treat can boost guest satisfaction and early feedback, leading to better reviews and repeat business.

11. Check Linen Stock levels

Review [linen levels](#), note shortages, and prepare orders. Also

 [Download: Linen Order Guide](#)

12. Check the Housekeeping Supplies

Check cleaning supplies and guest amenities using the included stock tracker.

 [Download: Housekeeping Purchasing Tracker](#)

13. Review of [GDS](#) & [OTA](#) Bookings

Confirm guest details early. If phone numbers are missing, contact their agent or the guest. This avoids issues after-hours.

 [Download: Learn more about the GDS](#)

14. System Rollover (End-of-Day Close)

[System Rollover](#) is how you close out the motel's business day—like a retail till closure. It ensures all revenue is captured, accounts are accurate, and the next day starts clean.

Before You Start:

- Check out all departures
- Charge [VCCs](#) and post minibar/[incidentals](#)
- Release or process [pre-authorisations](#)
- Count and log the [cash float](#)
- Print receipts if needed

Rollover Steps:

- Run a [Trial Rollover](#) – Review totals in your [PMS](#): room revenue, payment types, and any refunds or discounts.
- Print EFTPOS Totals – Match these with [PMS](#) figures for Visa, Amex, EFTPOS, and refunds.
- [Reconcile Discrepancies](#) – Fix errors or flag for follow-up.

- Finalise Rollover – Once totals match, complete the rollover to lock in data and start a new business day.
- Save Reports – File the final [PMS](#) report, EFTPOS totals, and any mismatch notes.

✓ Tip: Always do a trial rollover first. Rushing leads to errors that create more work later. Train staff to double-check the figures.

 **Download:** [Our Motel Rollover Explainer Guide](#)

15. Communication with Housekeeping

Check progress throughout the day. If a housekeeper is behind, reallocate rooms or offer support—but communicate first, especially if they’re paid per room.

Monitor:

- Are [priority rooms](#) on track?
- Any maintenance issues flagged by housekeepers?
- Are room statuses updated in the PMS [Vacant Dirty \(VD\)](#) → [Inspect](#) → [Vacant Clean \(VC\)](#)?
- Have [VIP](#) amenities been placed correctly?

✓ Tip: Use WhatsApp for housekeeping logs and photo-based quality checks. This improves communication and tracks cleanliness issues.

16. Guest & [OTA](#) Communication

- Review bookings and special requests from OTAs.
- Respond promptly to emails, messages, and guest reviews.

✓ Tip: Timely, thoughtful responses to reviews can improve OTA rankings and boost bookings.

17. Balance Rooms & Adjust Rates

- Check arrivals for today and the next 7 days.
- Ensure room types are well distributed and adjust as needed. You want to keep a balance of different room types available where possible.
- If entry-level rooms ([lead-in room](#)) are sold out, consider upselling or complimentary upgrades to reopen inventory online.

18. Process [Virtual Credit Card \(VCC\)](#) Payments.

Charge all VCCs as per OTA policy and update [guest folios](#) accordingly. Follow your motel's procedures, and ensure payments are completed before check-out or per the charge date.

 **[Download: Guide to Virtual Credit Cards](#)**

19. Front Desk Presentation.

- Keep reception clean, tidy, and welcoming—it shapes guest impressions.
- Wipe counters and surfaces
- Organise and label key storage
- Display awards, brochures, and local info neatly
- Restock guest items and stationery
- Back up booking data (especially for non-cloud PMS)

✓ Minimise clutter. A clean desk signals professionalism and care.

20. Keys Returned.

Ensure all room keys are returned. If missing:

- Ask housekeeping to recheck their trolley
- Check key drop box
- Contact the guest
- Unresolved? Change the lock barrel promptly to maintain security. Use certified trades for fire-rated doors. Log and report key issues as part of daily procedures.

21. Refill any guest welcome packs, prepare breakfast bags.

22. Add payment instructions for bookings on arrival.

Review all arrivals and clearly add payment notes (e.g., “Pay on Arrival,” “Charge to VCC,” or “Company Chargeback”). Use consistent formatting so all staff can follow procedures seamlessly.

✓ Best Practice: Where possible, collect a personal credit card for security. Corporate guests may be exempt but always follow your motel’s policy.

 [**Download: Room Payment Methods**](#)

23. Guest Registration Cards

[Print Registration \(reg\) cards](#) if required. Highlight only the fields you want the guest to complete. Digital check-in may streamline this step if your PMS supports it.

✓ A signed reg card helps prevent payment disputes and avoids check-in errors like booking mix-ups.

Relaxing Stay Motel
GUEST REGISTRATION CARD

Relaxing Stay Motel
GUEST REGISTRATION CARD

Guest Name: John

Arrival Date:

Departure Date:

Room Type: King Deluxe

No. of People: 1 Adult 1 Child

Company Name: Big Friendly Co

Email: JohnGoodguest@BigFriendlyCo

Mobile Number: _____

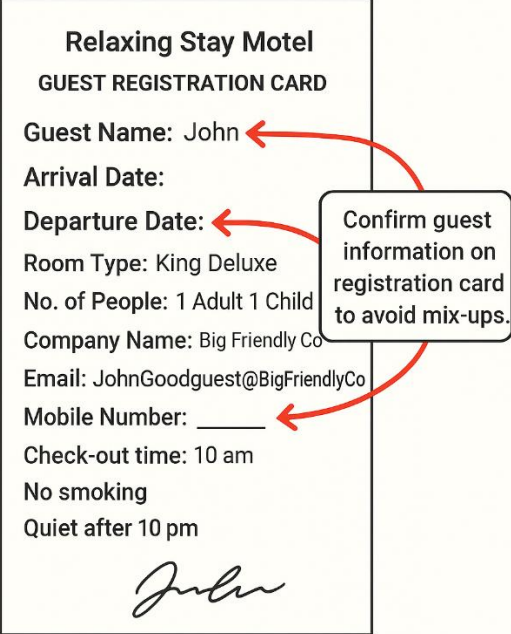
Check-out time: 10 am

No smoking

Quiet after 10 pm

John

Confirm guest
information on
registration card
to avoid mix-ups.



24. Room Inspections

For motels under ~30 rooms, the Manager should inspect all the cleaned rooms daily.

✓ Inspections reinforce standards and support consistent housekeeping quality.

 [Download: Room Inspection Checklist](#)

25. Group & Long Stay Bookings

- Monitor long-stay payments to avoid overdue balances.
- For groups, track deposits, deadlines, and changes with clear contracts and calendar reminders.

✓ Avoid financial losses by ensuring payments follow agreed terms.

✓ Solid terms protect your business; flexibility should be a goodwill gesture, not an expectation.

 [Download: Group Booking Guide](#)

26. Housekeeping Forecast & Next-Day Arrivals

- Review arrivals and adjust staffing if needed.
- Reallocate rooms proactively for VIPs or requests.

✓ Pre-checking guest info avoids surprises and improves review scores.

27. Guest Arrivals – Check-In Process

- Greet by name
- Verify photo ID
- Confirm booking details (dates, room type, inclusions)
- Complete [reg card](#) (highlight only required fields)

✓ Only collect what's necessary—avoid storing excess guest data.

Reiterate any important terms such as **check-out time**, **no smoking policy**, or **quiet hours**, and invite questions if anything is unclear.

During check-in, offer relevant upsells like late checkout or room upgrades based on your goals—either boosting revenue or guest satisfaction. Collect payment or process a pre-authorisation using a physical card for security. Mark the guest as checked in in your PMS, record any preferences, and issue room keys with welcome materials. Provide a brief orientation if appropriate, covering essentials like parking, room features, or local dining. Use this time to reconfirm booking details and ensure the guest has the most suitable room for their stay.

28. Guest Enquiries & Maintenance

Respond to guest requests promptly and follow up after resolution to confirm satisfaction. Proactive service prevents escalation and improves guest experience.

29. Check for Pending Folios or [Unassigned rooms](#)

Check [PMS](#) for new bookings and assign rooms as needed.

30. Late Check-In Procedures

Avoid unsafe practices like leaving keys in rooms or under mats. Use secure key safes with rotating access codes. Monitor after-hours bookings for potential risk—consider ID verification or security bonds where necessary to protect guests and your property.

31. Ensure Petty Cash Is Counted, Logged, and Finalized Daily

At the end of each shift, count, record, and balance petty cash. Use a logbook to ensure accuracy, prevent discrepancies, and

maintain accountability—especially with multiple staff. Regular checks simplify monthly reporting and audits.

 [Download: Petty Cash Tracker](#)

32. End-of-Day Close (Tasks 32-37 in checklist)

- Check for last-minute bookings and arrange after-hours access if needed
- Lock up all keys, guest data, and paperwork
- Confirm after-hours contact info is visible and working
- Activate “No Vacancy” sign if full and check all signage visibility
- Secure storerooms, shared facilities, and the pool area as required

- End of Front Office Checklist -

1. Customer Service

- Exceptional service drives reviews, repeat business, and reputation. Here’s how to deliver it consistently:
- Smile, even on the phone – It lifts your tone and projects warmth.
- Use guest names – Personalisation builds instant rapport.
- Offer thoughtful extras – Hold luggage, print documents, or share local tips—small gestures make lasting impressions.
- Listen and acknowledge – Address concerns with focus and empathy, even if you can’t fix them immediately.

- Be proactive – Offer help before guests ask. Spot discomfort?
- Stay calm and positive – Your attitude shapes the guest's experience.
- Personalise special occasions – A simple note or small treat goes a long way.

2. Debtors

Debtors are guests, companies, or agents who have stayed but not yet paid. This is common for corporates, groups, and agencies on invoicing terms (e.g. 7–30 days). Accounts Receivable reflects the total owed to the motel.

Understanding and managing debtors is crucial. Your role is to ensure all invoices are accurate, sent to the correct contact, and paid within agreed terms. Use your PMS to generate a [Debtors Report](#) and track [aged balances](#).

✓ Example: If a client's payment terms are 30 days and their invoice is 45 days overdue, it's your responsibility to follow up.

Tips to Manage Debtors Effectively:

- Only offer credit with owner approval—especially in high-occupancy markets.
- The longer a debt ages, the harder it is to recover. Some OTAs void claims after 90 days – but understand your OTA contracts as they vary.
- Monitor accounts weekly and act early.

Clearing Outstanding Debtors – Step-by-Step

- Find the original booking in the PMS (guest name, rate, inclusions).
- Confirm rates and charges match what was agreed.
- Check for extras (minibar, damages) and ensure they're authorised.
- Attach the correct booking reference to the invoice.
- Verify the invoice was sent to the correct contact with clear payment terms.
- Follow up via email if overdue—attach the original invoice.
- Call if needed—speaking to the right contact often speeds resolution.
- Apply payment in the PMS once received and save remittance advice.

✓ Tip: Always CC yourself when sending invoices or reminders for tracking.

3. Managing and Quoting Groups

Group bookings can boost revenue but may limit profitability if they block higher-value guests. Before confirming a group, consider:

- Will it displace longer or higher-paying stays?
- Are the rates competitive?
- Will it impact loyal or VIP guests?

To protect revenue:

- Limit the number of rooms allocated to groups
- Raise rates on remaining rooms
- Require direct bookings to avoid [OTA](#) fees
- Set minimum stay requirements

Strategic group management ensures you maximise revenue without sacrificing long-term value.

 [Download: Guide to Managing Groups](#)

4. Securing Guest Information

As the Motel Manager you are accountable for the safe storage of guest and company data. We recommend for motels to spend some time putting in place training and procedures to keep your guest data secure. As a starting point we have put together a Beginners Guide to Securing your guest data, and we will add relevant links, and important governing bodies in the space as we refine and add to the document.

 [Download: Securing Guest Data: A Beginners Guide](#)

5. Handling Guest Complaints

Responding to guest complaints with professionalism and empathy is an essential part of maintaining your motel's reputation and guest satisfaction. Use the following steps as a guide:

- **Listen fully** – Allow the guest to explain the issue without interruption. Let them feel heard.
- **Acknowledge and empathise** – Show genuine concern and understanding for their frustration.

- **Resolve promptly** – Take immediate steps to address the issue where possible.
- **Document** – Always record the complaint, how it was resolved, and any follow-up required.

Each motel will have its own approach to managing guest compensation. Some offer gestures such as late checkout, a small gift, or a refund, while others may simply acknowledge the issue and offer a sincere apology. If your motel does not provide compensation for service errors, the best practice is to apologise clearly, reassure the guest that the issue has been resolved, and thank them for their feedback.

Follow-up is key. Once an issue is resolved—whether it’s a faulty air-conditioner or a delayed room clean—check in with the guest to confirm they are satisfied with the outcome. This not only ensures their expectations have been met but also gives you an opportunity to rebuild rapport and demonstrate care. In some cases, a small additional gesture can go a long way. Leaving a handwritten apology note with a chocolate or offering a complimentary bottle of wine for more serious inconveniences shows your commitment to guest satisfaction and can turn a negative experience into a positive review.



[**Download: Handling Guest Complaints**](#)

For structured training and support beyond this guide, our Motel Management courses build on the systems outlined here.

Chapter 3: Housekeeping

Housekeeping Essentials for Motel Managers

Housekeeping is the foundation of guest satisfaction. Whether your motel has 15 or 50 rooms, clean, well-prepared rooms drive good reviews and return stays. As a manager, you don't need to clean every room — but you do need to understand what “clean” looks like, how long it takes, and how to support your team to do it consistently.

Your Role

In a small motel, managers are often hands-on. You may clean rooms, inspect them or support your team during peak turnover days. Your job is to set the standard, provide tools and structure, and ensure nothing gets missed between check-outs and new arrivals.

Use checklists, walk-throughs, and proper scheduling. Don't expect perfection without systems.

Team Management and Leadership

Start with Observations. Don't walk in making changes. Spend the first 1–2 weeks observing existing routines, listening to staff, and noting what works and what doesn't. Build trust early. Sudden changes can cause staff to leave before you fully understand the operation.

Introduce Change the Right Way

Explain why changes matter, be consistent across the team, and invite input. Changes work best when staff feel involved, not dictated to.

Feedback That Works

- Praise specifically and frequently: “Thanks for the detail on the shower — it looked great.”
 - Address concerns privately: Stay calm, be task-focused, and don’t blame.
 - Refer to standards, not personal habits: “Our standard is...” not “You always...”
 - Follow up: If performance issues persist, ask whether it’s a training issue, a resources problem, or a motivation concern.
-

Rostering Smart

Build rosters around check-in/check-out patterns, staff availability, and room types. Your roster is one of the most powerful tools for controlling costs, maintaining quality, and keeping staff happy.

Tips:

- Forecast using PMS bookings. Include a “pickup buffer” for last-minute bookings.
- Balance staff by skill level, room types, and expected early arrivals.

- Consistency matters: avoid last-minute shift changes if possible.

✓ Tip: Keep a list of backup cleaning tasks for slow days—deep cleans, storeroom restocks, or common area checks.

Scheduling for Flexibility

Starting early gives you flexibility. A 7 am shift allows you to respond to early check-in requests or cover for a no-show housekeeper. But don't schedule too early if most guests don't check out until 10am. Balance start times to maximize productivity.

Use downtime wisely:

- Refill housekeeper caddies and trolleys
- Clean public areas
- Organise storage areas
- Train staff on cross-departmental tasks (e.g., using the PMS)
- Train multiple housekeepers in reception basics so they can step in if needed. This builds loyalty and cross-functional capability.

**HOUSEKEEPING
TROLLEY**



**HOUSEKEEPING
CADDY**



Prioritising and Preparing Rooms

Start each day with a printed arrivals report from your [PMS](#).

Highlight:

- VIPs
- Early check-ins
- [Stayovers](#) (ask guests if they want service)
- Special requests (e.g. twin beds, allergy-friendly rooms)

From this, build your **Housekeeping Room List**, assigning rooms and tasks to each housekeeper. Prioritise based on arrival time and request type.

✓ Tip: Good pre-arrival planning saves time and avoids guest disappointment.

Room Quality Control

Inspect rooms before marking them as clean in the PMS. For small motels, this might be your job; in larger ones, a housekeeping supervisor can assist.

What to check:

- Bed made tightly with fresh linen
- Bathroom fully cleaned and dried
- Amenities restocked
- Room vacuumed, mopped, and aired out
- AC/heating turned on to guest-appropriate level
- Maintenance issues logged
- Room smells fresh, looks polished

✓ Spend a night in one of your own rooms occasionally to experience what your guests experience.

Linen & Amenities Stock

Keep linen and supplies at optimal “[PAR](#)” levels (3–5 sets per room). Track usage to avoid shortages. Organise linen trolleys neatly to save time and reduce errors. Dirty linen should never be stored on the floor or left exposed.

✓ Have a restock list visible in the laundry room and check it weekly.

Deep Cleaning & Preventative Tasks

Don't wait for guests to report issues. Use scheduled **deep cleans** to maintain quality. These include cleaning behind beds, scrubbing grout, and replacing stained linen.

Create a Deep Cleaning Schedule and rotate rooms weekly.
Assign deep cleans on slower days.

Cost Control

Track how long each room takes to clean. Set realistic benchmarks (e.g., 30 mins for a standard double). Over time, calculate your cost per room and monitor for inefficiencies.

Example:

- 50 rooms cleaned in 30 staff hours = 36 minutes per room
 - If next week you clean 40 rooms in 35 hours - red flag?
 - Investigate: dirtier rooms? slower staff? extra tasks?
- Then adjust.

✓ Tip: Clean rooms yourself occasionally to test your benchmarks and train new staff.

Equipment & Setup

Optimise the flow of work by planning where equipment lives. Avoid double handling or unnecessary walking. Trolleys should be:

- Light and easy to manoeuvre
- Not taken into guest rooms
- Stocked neatly with all essentials
- Labelled for easy access

Check that housekeepers don't block corridors or emergency exits, and that they're trained in safe manual handling.

WHS (Workplace Health & Safety)

You are responsible for ensuring all housekeeping staff are trained in chemical safety, manual handling, and emergency procedures.

Keep up-to-date **Safety Data Sheets (SDS)** for all cleaning chemicals, ensure PPE is available (gloves, goggles, aprons), and store chemicals safely in locked areas.

✓ Download and maintain a chemical register, SDS log, and spill response guide. Review annually.

Bed Bugs & Pest Prevention

Housekeepers are your front line for pest detection. Train them to spot signs of bed bugs:

- Blood spots on linen
- Musty smell
- Bugs in seams or behind headboards

Act immediately if found. Quarantine the room, notify pest control, and do not re-enter or reassign until cleared.

✓ Use sealed laundry bags, keep linen off floors, and disinfect trolleys to reduce risk.

Training & Onboarding

Train new staff with a clear onboarding checklist:

- Room cleaning standards
- Trolley setup
- Linen handling
- Chemical safety
- Handling DND rooms and VIPs
- Reporting maintenance

Use 2-minute micro-trainings weekly to reinforce skills and expectations. Rotate topics — from stain removal to time-saving tips.

Final Words

Housekeeping is where guest satisfaction lives or dies. As a manager, your job is to lead with consistency, structure, and support. You don't need to do it all — but you need to make sure it gets done right, every time.

A well-run housekeeping operation doesn't just keep rooms clean — it builds guest loyalty, drives reviews, and protects your bottom line.

Chapter 4: Maintenance

Maintenance in a motel is about more than fixing things when they break. It's about **preventing issues**, ensuring **safety**, and meeting **legal obligations**. As a motel manager, you may not be a qualified tradesperson—but you're responsible for making sure everything runs smoothly, safely, and efficiently.

Key Maintenance Concepts

- **Preventative Maintenance:** Scheduled tasks that reduce future issues
- **Reactive Maintenance:** Fixing problems after they occur
- **Compliance:** Legal checks and safety standards that must be met
- **Asset Register:** List of key equipment and their condition
- **Tag & Test:** Annual electrical checks on appliances
- **WHS:** Work Health & Safety obligations for staff and guests

✓ Tip: You don't need to do it all—just ensure the right tasks are tracked, delegated, and documented.

Set Up a Simple Maintenance System

Use a spreadsheet to track tasks across:

- Daily, weekly, and monthly inspections
- Compliance tasks (fire, electrical, WHS)
- Asset servicing schedules
- Stock levels (e.g., lightbulbs, filters, batteries)
- Preferred contractors and emergency contacts

 [Download: Maintenance Template + Tracker](#)

Daily and Weekly Checks

Daily Tasks:

- Walk the property and check for hazards
- Test pool gates, exits, and light bulbs
- Log any urgent issues

Weekly Tasks:

- Test smoke alarms and emergency lights
- Run taps, flush unused toilets (prevents Legionella)
- Inspect equipment (e.g., laundry, A/C)

✓ Do checks early in the week to allow time for repairs before weekends.

Monthly and Seasonal Checks

Monthly Tasks:

- Clean or replace A/C filters
- Inspect pest activity
- Touch up paint or check walls for wear
- Schedule “test and tag” as needed

Seasonal Prep:

- Service heaters in summer before winter
- Service A/Cs in winter before summer
- Service pool filters during off-season

✓ Fixing it before peak season avoids guest complaints and revenue loss.

Compliance Essentials

Your motel must meet legal standards in areas like fire safety, chemical use, and WHS. Schedule compliance tasks in advance.

Common Requirements:

- Fire extinguisher tests every 6 months
- Smoke alarm checks monthly and annually
- Pool fencing and signage inspections
- Electrical appliance testing every 12 months
- Emergency light testing every 6 months

✓ Store all records in a folder labelled “Compliance & Maintenance” and back up digital copies.

Contractor Management

Build a reliable list of licensed trades: electricians, plumbers, pest control, A/C, fire services.

Track:

- License and insurance expiry dates
- Response time and quality
- Preferred contact details

When requesting work:

- Provide a clear written scope
- Ask for fixed pricing, inclusive of GST
- Confirm who is doing the work (You want to avoid your trades subcontracting work out where possible).

✓ Get 2–3 quotes for large jobs and store them with related approvals. Keep it simple and ensure all quotes are inclusive of taxes and any fees.

Maintenance Troubleshooting

Guests expect fast solutions. Learn to troubleshoot basic issues and document steps for future reference.

5-Step Process:

1. **Observe the Problem** – What’s the actual issue? Get full details.
2. **Check the Obvious** – Power, batteries, settings, breakers
3. **Isolate the Cause** – Room-specific? System-wide?
4. **Fix or Escalate** – DIY if safe, or call licensed help
5. **Log It** – Record issue, fix, who handled it, and outcome

✓ Tip: Build a Troubleshooting Logbook to help others handle problems in your absence.

Common Maintenance Issues

Problem	Quick Check
A/C not cooling	Clean filter, check remote batteries, reset unit
Hot water issues	Reset system, check pilot light or circuit
Lights not working	Replace globe, check breaker
Toilet leaking	Check cistern, valve, and float arm
Smoke alarm beeping	Replace battery, test, check expiry
TV remote not working	Check input/source, replace batteries
Wi-Fi issues	Restart router, verify login, notify provider

 [Download: Common Maintenance Issues](#)

✓ Note: Never DIY gas, electrical, or fire safety repairs—always use a licensed professional.

Preventative Action

After fixing a problem, ask: **Can this be prevented next time?**

If yes, add it to your maintenance schedule.

Examples:

- A/C not cooling → add monthly filter check
 - Hot water failure in winter → schedule pre-winter system service
 - Smelly drains → plan 6-monthly cleaning
-

Maintenance Logs

For every repair or inspection, log:

- Date
- Room or area
- Description of problem
- Who fixed it
- Action taken

This history helps you identify recurring issues and justify future upgrades or expenses.

✓ Tip: Keep a whiteboard in the back office with priority tasks to ensure visibility.

Spare Parts & Supplies

Keep a well-stocked supply of frequently needed items:

- Light globes
- A/C filters
- Remote batteries
- Plumbing washers
- Electrical tape
- Zip ties
- Basic tools (screwdrivers, tester, pliers)

✓ Store in a mobile toolbox for quick access.

Guest Communication

Leave a short note after maintenance work is done. For example:

"Hi John,

Just letting you know the air-conditioner in your room has been checked and reset. We're sorry for the inconvenience and hope you enjoy the rest of your stay. – [Your Name]"

A handwritten card or small chocolate goes a long way toward turning a problem into a 5-star review.

Final Word

A well-run maintenance system doesn't just reduce breakdowns—it builds trust with your guests, improves staff morale, and protects your business.

Track tasks, build vendor relationships, and act early. When done well, maintenance is one of the most powerful tools you have for long-term success.

Conclusion

Motel management is about more than operations — it's about people. Each guest brings a story, and how you lead shapes their experience. You've now learned the essentials, but what matters most is how you apply them with care, purpose, and calm leadership.

Glossary

Aged Accounts	Aged accounts are unpaid invoices that are grouped by how long they've been overdue—typically shown in time brackets like 0–30 days, 31–60 days, 61–90 days, and 90+ days—to help track and manage outstanding payments.
Check-in Envelope / Late Check-in Envelope	An envelope prepared for guests arriving after hours, includes room key(s) and welcome info.
DNM (Do Not Move)	Note indicating that the guest must stay in the assigned room (e.g., for health or accessibility reasons).
Debtors Report	A Debtors Report is a financial summary that shows all outstanding payments owed to the motel by guests, companies, or agencies, often

	broken down by how long each invoice has been overdue (aged accounts).
Express Checkouts	Express Checkouts are where a guest leaves their key in a box or in the room. This is generally when there is nothing left to settle on their account or the balance will be settled with the card on file.
Float / Cash Float	Small amount of cash kept at reception for change and petty transactions.
GDS (Global Distribution System)	A network used by travel agents and corporate bookers to reserve accommodation.
Guest Collect	The guest pays the motel directly, not the OTA.
Guest Folio	A guest folio is the running account or invoice in your Property Management System (PMS) that records all charges and payments for a guest's stay.
Par Level	Periodic Automatic Replenishment it's the minimum quantity of an item you hold before reordering – example, you might have a PAR Level of King Sheets of 100, when you only have 100 King Sheets left you would re-order.
Housekeeping Sheet / Task Sheet	A list used by housekeeping to track and assign rooms, includes cleaning and guest notes.
Inspect	The status showing the room has been cleaned but is pending a final inspection.
Incidentals	Incidentals refer to additional charges that a guest may incur on top of the room rate during their stay.
Lead-in Room	Refers to the most basic and lowest-priced room category available at the property.

OTA (Online Travel Agent)	Booking platforms like Booking.com, Expedia, or Agoda.
Guest Profiles	A Guest profile allows you to make notes for a guest such as preferences and if they have previous had issues.
Pay on Arrival (POA)	Guest pays on check-in or check-out; may involve pre-authorization.
PMS (Property Management System)	Software used to manage bookings, billing, guest details, and room status.
Pre-auth (Pre-authorization)	A credit card hold for security; funds are not charged but are temporarily held.
Reg Card (Registration Card)	Form confirming guest details and agreement to motel terms, filled at check-in.
RevPAR (Revenue per Available Room)	Metric blending ADR and occupancy. Formula: $ADR \times Occupancy\ Rate$
Reconcile	To compare two sets of records—like payments and bookings—to make sure they match and there are no errors.
Room Only (RO)	Room rate includes only the room — no meals or extras.
Split Payment	Payment split between methods or among guests.
Split Beds	In a motel where a large bed can be split into 2 single beds.
System Rollover	End-of-day process to reconcile PMS and EFTPOS and close out the shift.
VCC (Virtual Credit Card)	Single-use card from OTAs to pay for bookings; often valid only on check-in day.
VC (Vacant Clean)	The room is clean and ready for new guests.

Inspect	A room that has been cleaned by Housekeeping but not yet inspected by a supervisor or manager.
Stayover	Stayover is a guest in-house that has a second booking or there reservation continues to the past today.
Priority or Rush Rooms	This is a term for Housekeeping and the Front Office to indicate that a room is needed ASAP.
Remittance Advice	Is a document sent by a customer to confirm that payment has been made, showing details like the invoice number, amount paid, and date—helping the motel match the payment to the correct account.
Trial Rollover	A trial Rollover is the process of printing a trial settlement and trial Eftpos summary for the rollover day and checking they match. Once they match you can then do a Rollover. Avoiding errors with Rollover keeps the paperwork accurate and avoids additional time in fixing issues.
ADR (Average Daily Rate)	The average room revenue per sold room, per night. Formula: Room Revenue ÷ Rooms Sold
All to A/C (All to Account)	All charges (room and extras) are billed to the guest's or company's account.
Chargeback	A reversed payment, usually resulting from a guest dispute with their credit card provider.
Unassigned Rooms	Guest bookings that don't have a room allocated to them yet.
VD (Vacant Dirty)	The room is empty but has not been cleaned after checkout.
VIP	Very Important Person

What to Do Next

This guide gives you a practical overview of how small motels are run day to day.

If you're already working in a motel or preparing to step into management, structured training can help you apply these systems with confidence and consistency.

Our Motel Management courses build on the frameworks and checklists outlined in this guide.

Contact Us

We'd love to hear from you — whether you have a question, want to share feedback, or are looking for support on your motel journey.

Motel Coach

Website: www.motelcoach.com.au

Email: contact@motelcoach.com.au

Looking for templates, spreadsheets, or personalised support? Visit our website for downloadable tools and resources tailored to new and growing motel managers.